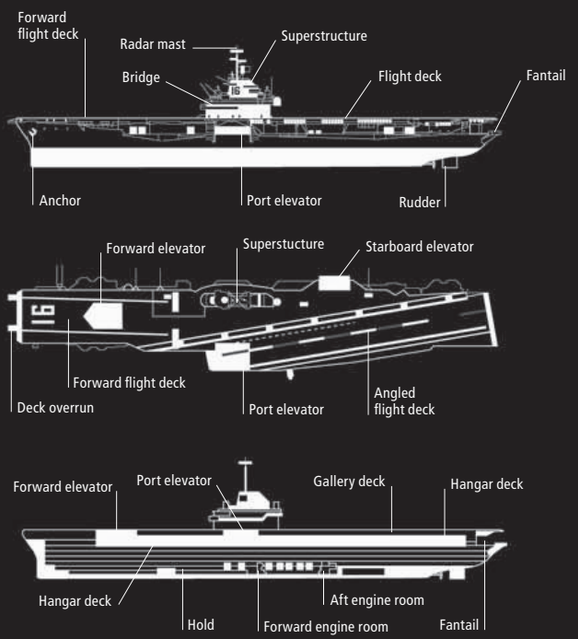
USS LEXINGTON

THE FIRST AIRCRAFT CARRIER to bear the name *Lexington* was sunk at the Coral Sea in 1942. The name was transferred to a new fleet carrier commissioned in 1943, which played a prominent part in the battles of the Philippine Sea and Leyte Gulf. *Lexington* remained in service until 1991, making her the longest serving carrier in the US Navy.

KNOWN AS THE "BLUE GHOST" because of her dark blue paint scheme, *Lexington* operated some 80 aircraft during World War II. The ship had the standard layout for a World War II carrier, with an island superstructure offset to starboard and aircraft taking off and landing along a straight flight deck stretching from the stern to the bow. With the aid of a steam-operated catapult and an arrestor cable, aircraft could take off and land using half the length of the flight deck, leaving the rest free for shifting planes up from and down to the hangars on lifts. If a landing went wrong, only a crash barrier prevented an aircraft piling into planes being marshalled on the deck. After the war, carriers were designed with a landing deck angled to port, so that if anything went wrong the landing pilot could accelerate off and come round for a second try. *Lexington* was given an angled flight deck during extensive modernization in the 1950s. By the time she was decommissioned in 1991, *Lexington* was the oldest working aircraft carrier in the US Navy. She is now a museum ship at Corpus Christi, Texas.



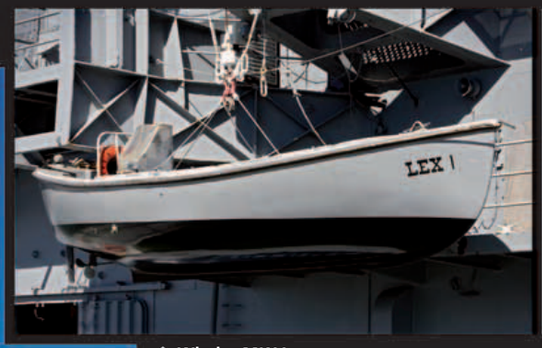
The Blue Ghost
At her permanent mooring in Corpus Christi, Texas, the floodlit shape of the *Lexington*, affectionately nicknamed the "Blue Ghost," can be seen from around the bay.



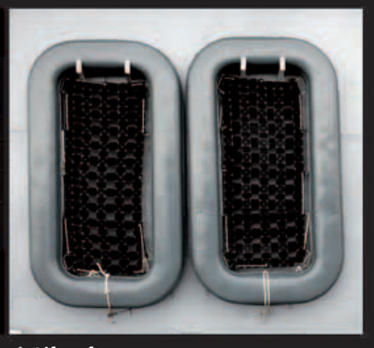
USS Lexington
The second Essex-class aircraft carrier to be commissioned, *Lexington* is 910 ft (275 m) long. She can carry enough fuel in her tanks to sail nonstop for a distance of 30,000 miles (50,000 km).

Superstructure
The island superstructure is the ship's command-and-control center. The radar mast carries six different radar systems as well as radio antennas and other equipment. Below this, the island houses the bridge, pilot-house, radar room, flight control center, and other key command areas.





Whaler MK11
Suspended from the starboard aft edge of the flight deck, the lightweight 26 ft (8 m) long Mk11 Whaler motorboat was used to ferry personnel to shore. It could carry up to 22 passengers.



Life rafts
Two rigid, puncture-proof life rafts known as Carley floats are fixed to the starboard side of the island. In case of emergency, the lightweight rafts could be launched simply by casting them into the water.

> "PILOTS ARE THE WEAPON OF THIS FORCE. PILOTS ARE THE THINGS YOU HAVE TO NURTURE. PILOTS ARE THE PEOPLE YOU HAVE TO TRAIN ... YOU HAVE TO TRAIN OTHER PEOPLE TO SUPPORT THE PILOTS."
>
> **ADMIRAL MARC MITSCHER,** COMMANDER OF FAST CARRIER TASK FORCE 58 ON *LEXINGTON*, 1941